

Direct and indirect speech

THERE ARE TWO WAYS OF REPRESENTING SPEECH IN WRITING.

When a person's exact words are reproduced in writing within quotation marks, this is known as direct speech. When a person's speech is reported, using neither the exact words nor quotation marks, it is called indirect or reported speech.

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Direct speech

Direct speech is always contained within quotation marks, indicating words that are spoken aloud by someone. Direct speech is usually written in the present tense (as it is spoken), and is accompanied by a simple clause in the past tense that tells the reader who is speaking.

What are your symptoms?



“What are your symptoms?” the doctor asked.

This direct speech gives the exact words of the doctor, so it is contained within quotation marks.

A comma is usually used to separate direct speech from its accompanying clause, but a question mark or exclamation point can be used instead.

This simple clause explains who is speaking.

Indirect speech

Indirect speech is also known as reported speech, because it is an account—or report—of what someone has said. Indirect speech does not require quotation marks. It is usually written in the past tense, because it is describing what someone has said. The present tense is occasionally used when reporting something that has always been—and remains—the case.



- Be careful when **converting speech** from direct to indirect. It must be clear from the **context** of the sentence or the **word order** which **pronoun** refers to which **person**.
- When writing **dialogue**, a **new line** should be started for **each new speaker**.

▷ Reporting back

These are not Peter's exact words, but they recount what he said, so this is an example of indirect speech.

Peter explained that his thumb kept twitching.

The third person is used because Peter is not the narrator.

▷ Stating facts

This indirect speech is reporting an unchanging fact, so the present tense is used.

He told the doctor that he spends all his time playing video games.

This means that he always has, does, and will spend his time playing video games.